

THANKSGIVING BORICUA

Acción de gracias con sabor isleño

The American holiday table, Puerto Rican style — pernil leading, rice and beans alongside, flan for the finish.

Authentic recipes · Bilingual · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

The Boricua Thanksgiving

On many boricua tables, turkey is optional and pernil is not. The Thanksgiving menu below swaps in the island classics that anchor Nochebuena and work beautifully at Thanksgiving: slow-roasted pork shoulder, rice with pigeon peas, stewed beans, and coconut for dessert. Same holiday spirit, better leftovers.

Pernil Asado — The Centerpiece

Pernil Asado — Slow-Roasted Puerto Rican Pork Shoulder Recipe

Pernil · Slow-roasted pork shoulder with crispy skin and garlicky mojo criollo. The Nochebuena centerpiece.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Arroz con Gandules

Arroz con Gandules — Authentic Puerto Rican Rice and Pigeon Peas Recipe

Arroz Con Gandules · Puerto Rico's national dish — rice, pigeon peas, and sofrito. The one-pot meal every boricua makes for holidays.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 1 can (15 oz) gandules (pigeon peas), drained
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup manzanilla olives with pimento
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a large caldero or heavy pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 2 minutes until fragrant.
2. Add drained gandules and cook for 3 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. Stir in sazón and cumin. Cook for 1 minute to bloom the spices.
4. Add rice and stir to coat every grain in the sofrito mixture.
5. Pour in chicken broth, add olives, and bring to a boil. Stir once, then reduce heat to low.
6. Cover tightly and cook for 25 minutes without lifting the lid. Fluff with a fork before serving.

Habichuelas Guisadas

Habichuelas Guisadas — Authentic Puerto Rican Stewed Beans Recipe

Habichuelas · The everyday Puerto Rican side dish — thick, savory bean stew with calabaza that accompanies rice on virtually every plate.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz) pink beans
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons tomato paste
- 1/2 cup pumpkin (calabaza) cubed
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon cumin
- 1 cup water
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 3 minutes until fragrant and softened.
2. Add tomato paste and cook for 1 minute, stirring constantly to caramelize it slightly.
3. Toss in the cubed pumpkin, sazón, and cumin. Stir to coat the pumpkin in the flavor base.
4. Add the beans (with their liquid) and water. Stir well and bring to a boil.
5. Reduce heat and simmer for 20 minutes until the pumpkin is fork-tender and the broth has thickened.
6. Mash some of the pumpkin pieces against the side of the pot to thicken the stew. Taste and adjust salt before serving.

Tembleque — Coconut Pudding

Tembleque — Puerto Rican Coconut Milk Pudding Recipe

Tembleque · A coconut milk pudding that literally jiggles — the holiday dessert on every Puerto Rican Christmas table.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (13.5 oz) coconut milk
- 1/2 cup cornstarch
- 1/2 cup sugar
- 1/4 teaspoon salt
- Ground cinnamon for dusting

Steps

1. In a small bowl, whisk the cornstarch with 1/2 cup of the coconut milk until completely smooth with no lumps. Set aside.
2. Pour the remaining coconut milk into a medium saucepan. Add the sugar and salt. Heat over medium, stirring occasionally, until it reaches a gentle simmer.
3. Whisk the cornstarch mixture one more time, then slowly pour it into the simmering coconut milk, whisking constantly.
4. Continue cooking and whisking for 3-5 minutes until the mixture thickens to a pudding consistency. It should coat the back of a spoon.
5. Pour into a mold, bundt pan, or individual cups. Let cool to room temperature, then cover and refrigerate for at least 4 hours until fully set.
6. To unmold, run a knife around the edges and invert onto a plate. Dust generously with ground cinnamon before serving.

The Thanksgiving Timeline

The night before: rub the pernil with its marinade, cover, and refrigerate. Make the tembleque and let it chill overnight. Thursday morning: put the pernil in a cold oven, roast low and slow. Two hours before serving: start the rice and the beans. Thirty minutes before: pull the pernil, let it rest under foil, then carve. Dessert needs nothing but a spoon.